That evening, Modi addressed a large gathering of the party faithful in Ahmedabad's JP Chowk. 'If there has been a mistake somewhere, if I have erred somewhere, I seek an apology from you, the six crore Gujaratis,' said the Gujarat chief minister. 'Gujarat is a role model for elections,' he added. 'The entire election was fought here on the plank of development. Gujarat has endorsed the plank of development. This victory is not the victory of Narendra Modi but of the six crore Gujaratis and those Indians who aspire for prosperity and development. This is a victory of all those who wish the country's good.'

This was clearly no routine victory speech. Showing a characteristic alertness to the political moment, it was delivered in Hindi and not Gujarati, designed for a national audience way beyond Gujarat. In the frenzied crowds, posters had sprung up: 'Modi chief minister 2012; prime minister 2014'. One Modi supporter even went to the extent of claiming 'Modi is India, India is Modi', reminiscent of Congress slogans for Indira Gandhi in the 1970s. As the 'PM, PM' chant echoed amidst the crowd throughout the speech, Modi obligingly said, 'If you want me to go to Delhi, I shall go there for a day on 27 December.'

In our studios that day too, Swapan Dasgupta was elated. It wasn't just a self-congratulatory 'I told you so' reaction—most exit polls had predicted a Modi win. He was convinced that Modi was now poised to take the great leap to the national capital. 'This is the beginning, we will now see a clear attempt to redefine Mr Modi's role in national politics', was his verdict. Modi's triumph carried the edge of a victory over the 'left liberals', a muffling of those critical voices which seemed to have dominated the mainstream. India's right-wing voices were waiting to burst through the banks and sweep aside the so-called 'secularists' who in their view had monopolized the discourse on Modi. Swapan seemed not just excited at Modi's victory but inordinately pleased at being able to cock a snook at his ideological opponents.

Others in the studio panel were a little more sceptical. After all, Modi wasn't the first chief minister to score a hat-trick of wins. Odisha's Naveen Patnaik, Sheila Dikshit in Delhi and, of course, the redoubtable Jyoti Basu